the issue to gain favorable domestic publicity by asserting India's role as protector of Indian communities abroad. Fiji's Indian population almost certainly will continue to count on New Delhi for help in protecting its rights. Constitutional changes depriving ethnic Indians of their rights would further erode confidence within the Indian community and trigger even more emigration. The departure of prosperous Indians from Fiji would eventually leave a poor Indian minority without political or economic clout.

Though Shekhawat had agreed with the CIA's assessment, he added that foreign powers like the USA had played a major role in installing Rabuka and their deafening silence after the coup was a clear indication of their tacit support to the military regime.

'We learned that Mahendra Chaudhary, who served as finance minister in the Bavadra government, had been arrested and grilled for hours by Rabuka's soldiers. Temples and Indian-owned shops were closed down and Rabuka had declared that Indians needed prior permission to hold prayer meetings. The life of the Indians in Fiji was caged/ recalled Shekhawat. 'We were forced to evacuate the R&AW agents including Kailash Singh from Suva sometime in August 1987 when violent protesters started targeting Indians.'

An earlier Indian intelligence report had noted:

By and large, the people of Indian origin in Fiji, particularly those working on farms in the rural areas, were emotionally quite devoted to their motherland —India—and they have kept up the religious and cultural traditions of India insofar as it was practicable at such a long distance and after loss of contact with the country for generations. This emotional devotion was